The next morning, German media opined the trial was, from gavel to gavel, a depressing spectacle. Leipziger Volkszeitung gave its verdict:

Death will not catch up with Honecker in the dock, and this is good. This old, stubborn man was secretly wishing for death in front of the judge and the cameras as his ultimate revenge. Perhaps it was just in time that the constitutional judges halted the trial proceedings to prevent the possibility that Honecker would die during it – and thus become a martyr.

The Tageszeitung contended that any ‘normal person’ indicted for manslaughter would long ago have been released from custody. However, in Honecker’s case, the ‘trial was overburdened with non-juridical considerations from the very start.’

Over in Chile, Deputy Foreign Minister Edmundo Vargas confirmed Honecker could enter the country if he fulfilled the requirements of Chilean law. Clutching his new passport issued by the Interior Ministry in Bonn, Honecker left Moabit prison a free man and was escorted to Tegel airport in a carload of detectives. He caught a connecting flight to Frankfurt, from where the journey to Santiago took twenty hours on Varig flight RG-741.

On touchdown, the other passengers were ushered out before Honecker stepped into the bright Chilean sunlight. Unaided, he walked down the gangway into the arms of Margot, making a victory sign before being rushed off to the VIP lounge where leaders of Chilean communist and socialist parties were waiting, some carrying flowers. ‘I find it hard to express my real feelings at this moment,’ he told the gathering, adding:

Behind me lie many difficult years in hospitals and more than five months in jail. Right at the beginning of this ordeal I